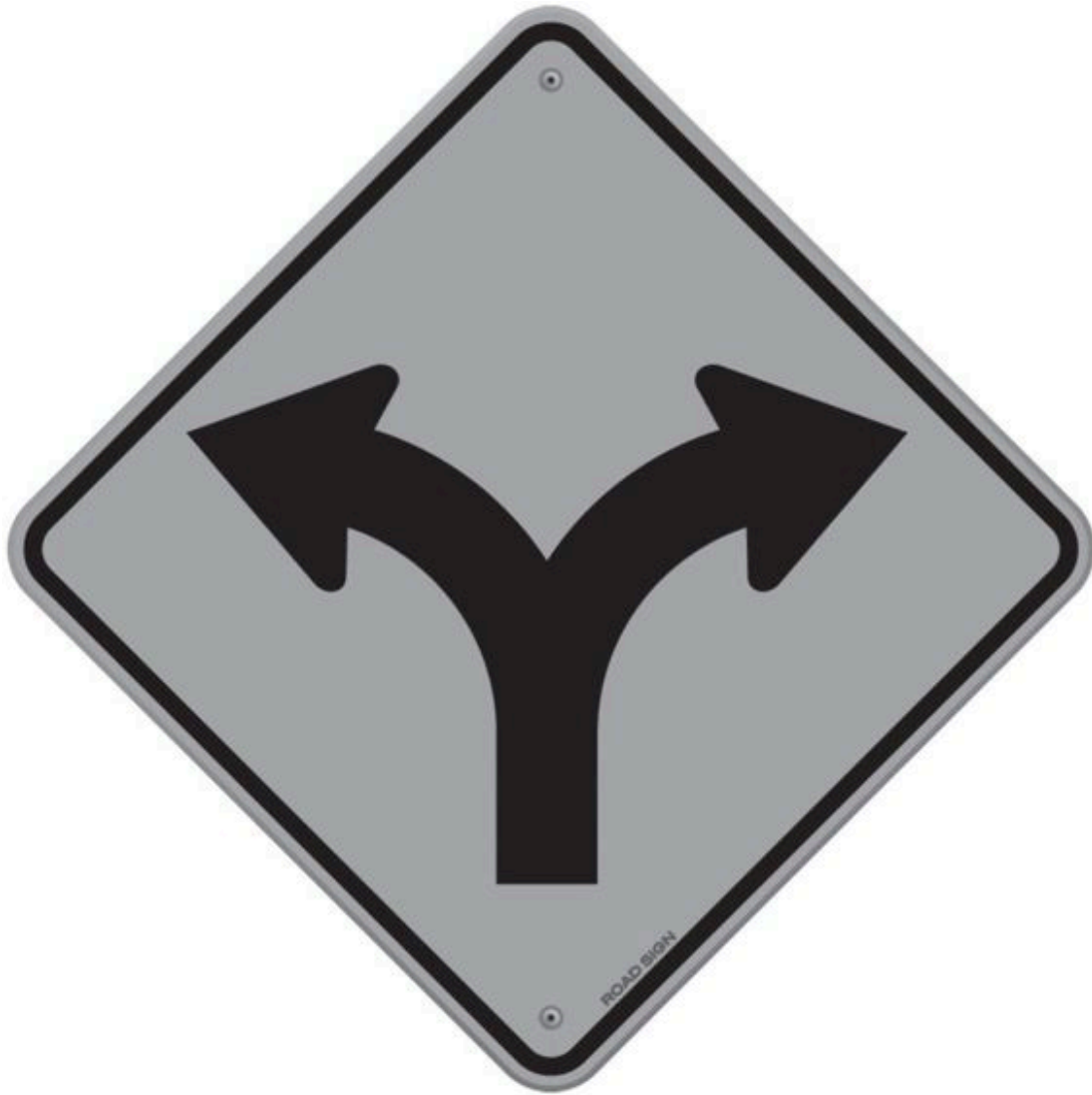


Hume's fork



The rationalist Leibniz had famously made the distinction between ‘two kinds of truths’ (see [To be is to be perceived](#)), those of reasoning and those of fact. Hume agreed, classifying statements as either ‘relations of ideas’ or ‘matters of fact’, akin to two different directions after a fork in the road. But Hume used the idea in a very different way from Leibniz. Truths of the first kind, analytic statements about ideas, are certain but depend on the definition of the terms they use, while truths of the second kind, synthetic statements of fact, refer to actual things in the world that we cannot be certain about. For example, the analytic statement ‘a square has four sides

of equal length' can be proved true as a relation of ideas, but since such perfection does not exist in the world, it tells us nothing about the world and does not prove a matter of fact. Nothing, Hume concluded, can be both certain *and* tell us something about the world; we cannot cross the fork from one road to the other and use a relation of ideas to prove a matter of fact.